Inquiry into the conduct of the 2025 Australian federal election

Committee Secretary
Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters
PO Box 6021
Parliament House
Canberra ACT 2600

Thank you for the opportunity to make this submission regarding the 2022 Australian federal election.

Australia's federal elections have changed in recent years, but the electoral system has not kept up with those changes. The increasing complexity and fragmentation of the party system has increasingly shown the single-member electorate system used to elect the House of Representatives to not be fit for purpose.

Australia's growing population needs a larger parliament, and it is time to make that change, forty years after the last significant expansion of the parliament.

In the aftermath of this election, and with a government re-elected with a large majority in the House of Representatives, this is an ideal opportunity to undertake serious electoral reform.

In this submission, I run through a number of issues and make a number of recommendations.

This is by no means a comprehensive list of every potential improvement that could be made to the electoral system for Australian federal elections, but includes a number of small changes and more significant changes that I believe to be timely. Some of these recommendations are similar to those that I made to this committee following the 2022 federal election, but there are some changes and additions.

I am available to attend a hearing if the committee wishes to hear more about the issues raised in this submission.

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List of recommendations

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Recommendation 2: The size of the Parliament should be expanded, with each state electing fourteen Senators, thus producing an increase in the number of members of the House of Representatives.

Recommendation 3: The number of Senators elected to represent the Australian Capital Territory and the Northern Territory be increased to at least four, with those Senators continuing to all be up for election at every House election.

Recommendation 4: The committee consider a legislative rule that would tie the number of senators for territories with a smaller population than the least populous state to a number that is in proportion to that state's per capita representation, and that territories with a larger population than the least populous state should have the same number of senators as the states.

About the author

I am an electoral analyst based in Sydney. I run a website called the Tally Room, as well as a podcast of the same name. Through this website, I analyse Australian elections (federal, state and local), writing seat-level guides for upcoming elections, analysing results and looking for trends in the data.

From time to time I also appear in other media publications analysing election results, including the Guardian Australia, the 7AM podcast, and various radio appearances. I have worked as an on-air election analyst for election night broadcasts for ABC Radio and assisted with the ABC TV election night broadcast for the 2025 federal election.

I have written chapters on the results in the House of Representatives for three successive academic publications analysing Australian federal elections: *Double Disillusion*, *Morrison's Miracle*, *Watershed* and the yet-to-be-published edition covering the 2025 federal election.

I have written this submission in a private capacity. I am not a member of any political party.

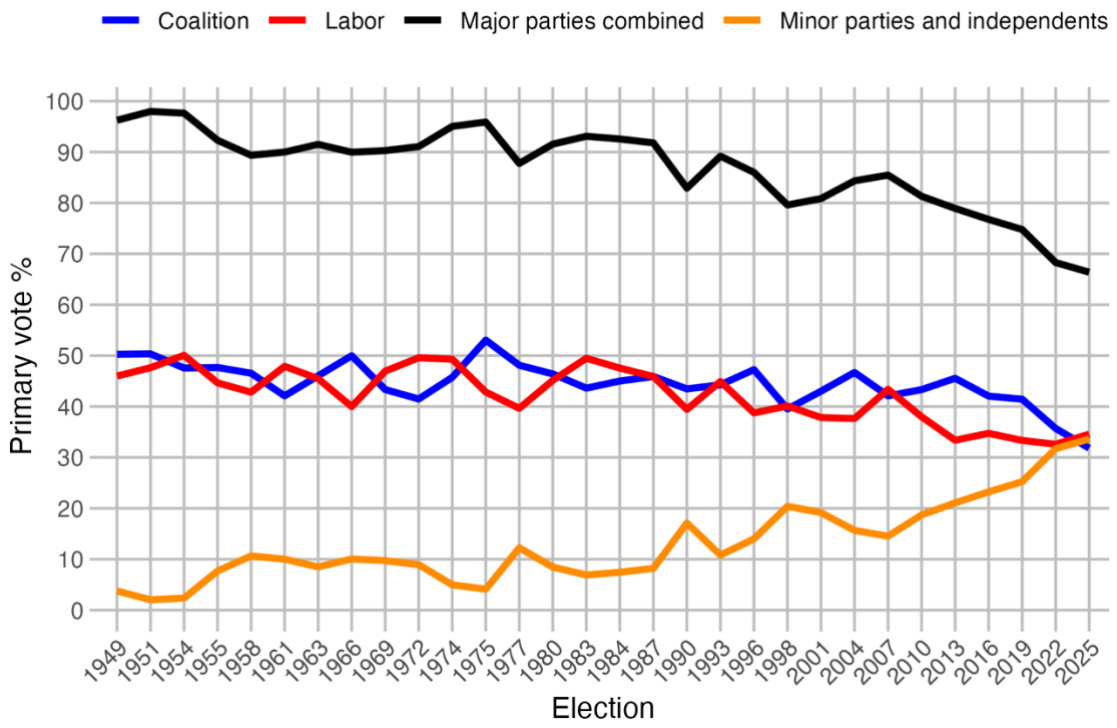
Proportional representation in the House of Representatives

The electoral system used to elect the House of Representatives is completely unsuited to the task set for it: to reflect the votes of Australians in a democratically-elected chamber.

The Australian Labor Party significantly over-represented in the new House, with the highest rate of disproportionality at least since the Second World War. Traditionally major parties have been over-represented in the House of Representatives. The poor result for the Liberal-National Coalition means that their representation is roughly in line with their share of the vote, but the current Labor government was able to win over 62% of seats with just 35% of the primary vote.

The 2025 election saw the combined vote for the major parties (Labor and the Liberal-National Coalition parties) drop to the lowest level since at least 1949. Yet, while we did see an increased crossbench, these parties still won over 91% of seats off just 66.4% of the primary vote. Labor won their largest landslide in the House of Representatives since 1943 with a primary vote share that would have produced a landslide defeat at any time until the last decade. The Coalition vote hit a new low, and for the first time was lower than the combined support for all minor parties and independents.[1]

Figure 1: Primary vote for major parties in the House of Representatives, 1949-2025



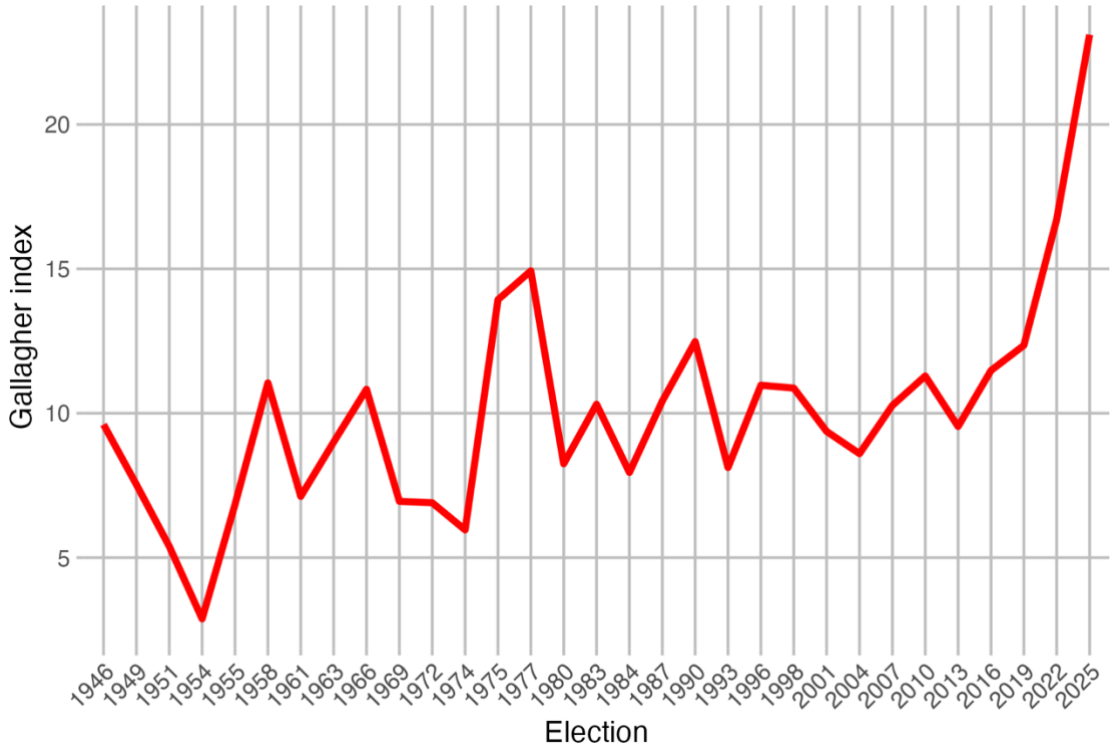
[1] "Australia 2025 – Wrap-up of the night", Ben Raue, *The Tally Room*, 4 May 2025 https://www.tallyroom.com.au/60426

There are many issues with single-member electorate systems. They create a class of safe seats, concentrating political efforts in marginal seats. They manufacture majorities of seats off a minority of the vote and increase the relevance of arbitrary drawing of electoral boundaries. But here I want to focus on some particular features that have become increasingly obvious at the 2022 and 2025 federal elections.

The party system has changed over recent decades and this has increased the disconnect between votes and seats.

The Gallagher index measures the level of disproportionality between the proportion of the vote and proportion of seats for each party. This metric has been gradually increasing over the last half-century, previously peaking in 1975 and 1977, but this metric spiked considerably in 2022, exceeding the level of disproportionality in the late 1970s, and was off the chart in 2025.

Figure 2: Disproportionality of Australian House elections, 1946-2025
Based on the Gallagher index of least squares

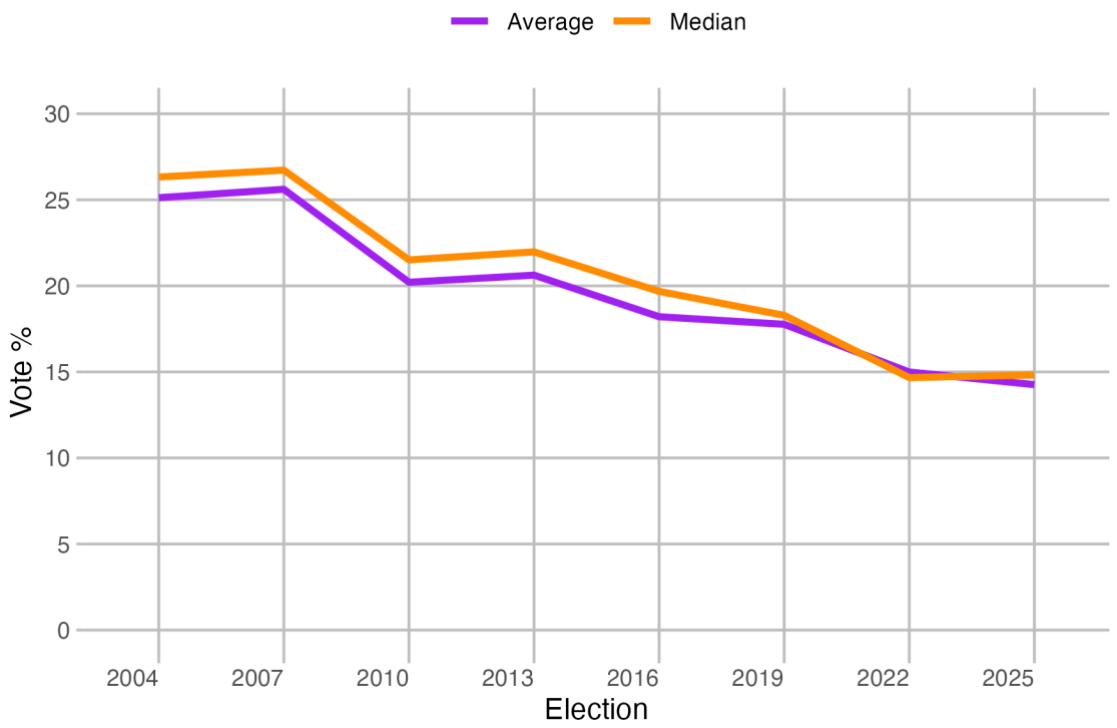


While the single-member electorate system was not particularly proportional in the 1950s, it played out quite differently in a context where most Australians voted for one of the major parties compared to the modern party system.

Until relatively recently, nearly every seat had two clear leading candidates. Votes cast for minor parties and independents flowed as preferences to one of the major parties, but there was little question about who would make it to the final count. There are increasing numbers of seats where that is no longer so clear.

Not only is there a greater diversity of voting patterns at a national level, but there are more electorates where there are three or more candidates who poll relatively well. The average gap between the second- and third-placed candidate has declined from about 25% in 2004-2007 to about 15% in 2022-2025.

Figure 3: Gap between second-placed and third-placed candidates, 2004-2025
Based on the final three-candidate-preferred count



This is leading to more results where the top two candidates are not clear, complicating the process of distributing preferences and increasing the importance of the specific order of elimination of candidates.[2]

The Australian Electoral Commission has begun to conduct indicative three-candidate-preferred counts where it is unclear which two candidates have made the two-candidate-preferred count, and where it could influence the result. In 2022, this process was conducted (to varying degrees of completeness) in four seats. In 2025, this process was conducted in thirteen seats.

[2] "Understanding 3CP trends", Ben Raue, *The Tally Room*, 27 June 2022 https://www.tallyroom.com.au/47966

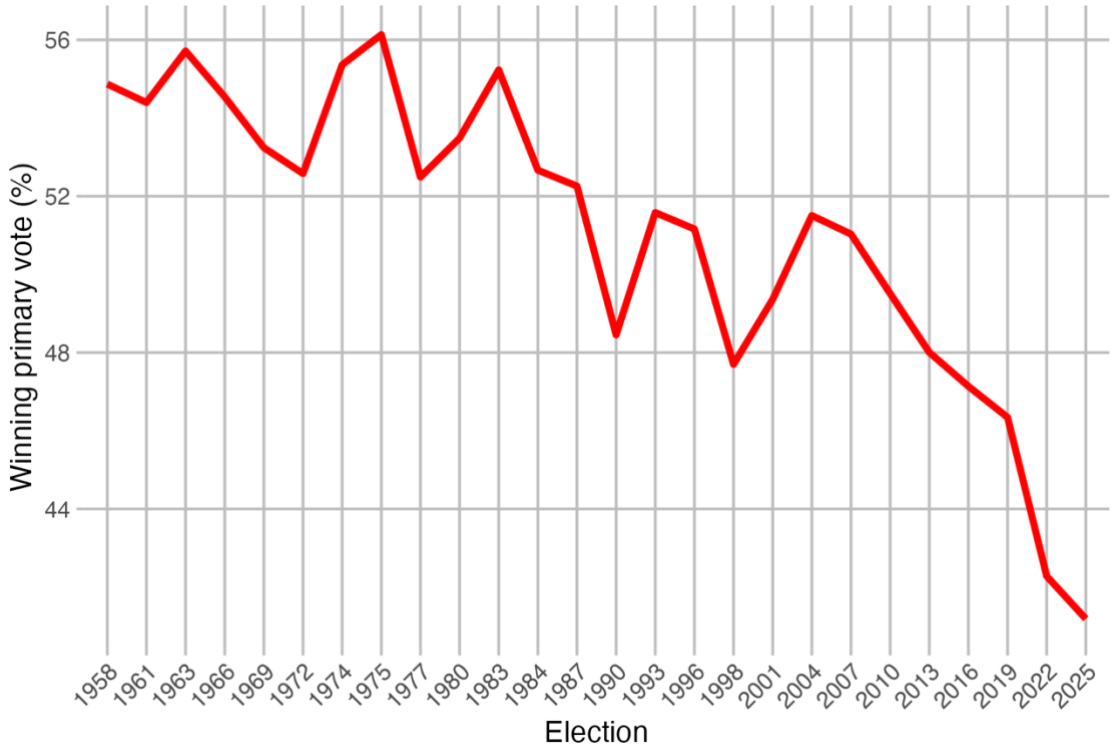
The average gap between second-placed and third-placed candidates has been shrinking significantly, from about 25% in 2004-2007 to about 15% in 2022-2025.

If current trends continue, more seats will be decided by slight differences in the distribution of preferences.

Not only are the national figures less representative of how people vote, but that's also true at a local level. The proportion of primary votes cast for a candidate who ends up winning has been dropping, from over half of the vote in past decades to just 41.2% in 2025.

Australian voters are much more likely to be represented only by someone they did not vote for. In contrast, a proportional system would give local residents a number of local members to contact, and it is far more likely one of them will be someone for whom they voted.

Figure 4: Share of primary votes cast for candidates who were elected, 1958-2025



The traditional appeal of single-member electorates is that they produce decisive results – a major party wins a majority of seats and forms a clear government. But if the primary vote for minor parties and independents remains high, that won't necessarily be the case. Large crossbenches will likely be elected, but the exact translation of votes into seats won't be predictable. Small shifts in votes can result in large shifts in seats.

The current electoral system is not well-designed to accommodate the increasingly diverse range of views in the Australian political system, and it's time for a change. I don't expect this committee to recommend a change, but we should be having the conversation now – how could it work, and what are the issues that need to be addressed?

Recommendation 1: A public inquiry be held into changing the electoral system for the House of Representatives to a system using proportional representation.

Expanding the size of Parliament

It's been over four decades since the Parliament was last expanded, and it's time to do so again.

The number of enrolled voters has increased from 9.9 million in 1984 to 18.1 million in 2025 – an increase of 83%. The number of divisions in the House of Representatives in that time has remained roughly the same, such that the average number of electors per division has increased from 66,664 in 1984 to 120,659 in 2025.

Table 1: Enrolment per division at select federal elections, 1901-2025

Election year	Enrolment	Divisions	Electors per division
1901	907,658	75	12,102
1946	4,744,017	75	63,254
1949	4,913,654	123	39,948
1983	9,373,580	125	74,989
1984	9,866,266	148	66,664
2001	12,636,631	150	84,244
2010	14,086,869	150	93,912
2016	15,676,659	150	104,511
2022	17,213,433	151	113,996
2025	18,098,797	150	120,659

The parliament has been expanded twice before, prior to the 1949 and 1984 elections. In order to expand the House, the Senate must be expanded. The 1949 expansion added four extra senators for each state, while the 1984 expansion added two, off a larger base, so proportionally the 1949 expansion is significantly greater.

I recommend expanding the number of senators per state by either two or four, which would add roughly 24-48 seats to the House of Representatives.

Table 2: Expected number of seats per state or territory, based on twelve, fourteen or sixteen senators per state

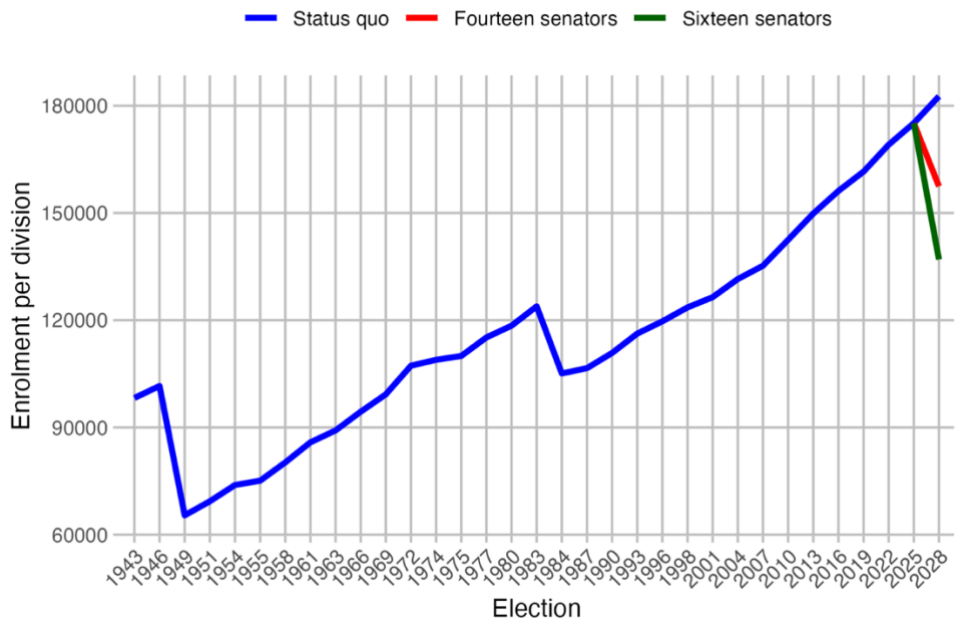
Population figures as of December 2024.

State/territory	12 senators	14 senators	16 senators
New South Wales	46	54 (+8)	62 (+16)
Victoria	38	44 (+6)	51 (+13)
Queensland	30	35 (+5)	40 (+10)
Western Australia	16	19 (+3)	22 (+6)
South Australia	10	12 (+2)	14 (+4)
Tasmania	5	5	5
Australian Capital Territory	3	3	4 (+1)
Northern Territory	2	2	2

Based on 2025 population statistics, this change would have increased the size of the House of Representatives from 150 to 174-200. These 24-50 extra divisions would be split up between the five most populous states, with the number of new divisions ranging from two for South Australia to eight for New South Wales. It would also solidify the Australian Capital Territory's claim to its third division (and even give the ACT a fourth seat in the 16-senator scenario) and the Northern Territory's claim to its second division.

An expansion to fourteen senators would reduce the average number of electors as of 2028 down to roughly the same average as in 2019. An expansion to fourteen senators would reduce the average back to 2010 levels.

Figure 5: Enrolment per division, 1949-2025, and estimated enrolment per division in 2028 depending on the number of senators elected per state



This slight expansion in the size of the House of Representatives would still leave the chamber relatively undersized compared to similarly-sized nations. Amongst countries within the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD), Poland and Canada, with 37-38 million people as of 2019, had lower houses with 460 and 338 members respectively. On the other hand, less populous countries like Chile, Netherlands and Belgium all had lower houses of 150-155 members.[3]

If you look at the total population per member of the lower house, Australia ranks sixth of 37 countries.

Recommendation 2: The size of the Parliament should be expanded, with each state electing fourteen Senators, thus producing an increase in the number of members of the House of Representatives.

Representation of the Territories in the Senate

It is time to reconsider the representation of the Territories in the Senate.

While you can apply the principle of "one vote one value" to the House of Representatives, it is not possible to do the same in the Senate.

The constitution mandates equal representation of each state, despite the most populous state New South Wales having about fifteen times the population of the least populous state Tasmania.

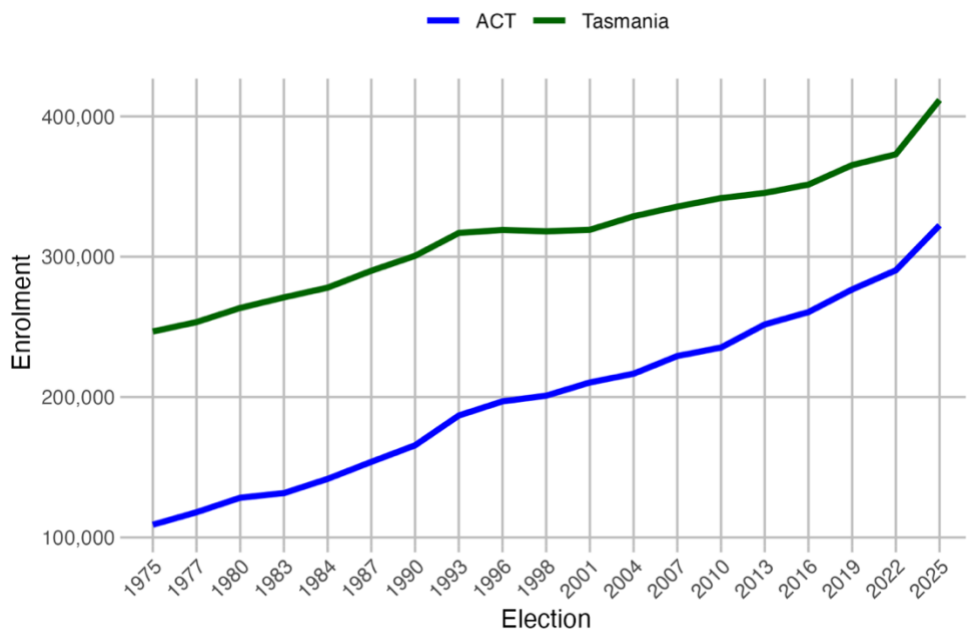
There has been some analysis comparing the number of senators representing the territories to their share of the national population. Each territory elects 2.6% of the total Senate, which is greater than their share of population.

This is a mistaken way to look at this issue. We don't impose expectations of 'one vote one value' on the state Senators who make up the vast bulk of the Senate, and I don't think we should apply that logic to the Territories.

Australians do not only engage in the federation as individual citizens, but also as states. A tremendous part of Australian government involves the interaction of federal and subnational governments, including the transfers of large amounts of tax revenue. The Senate represents those jurisdictions equally, except for the territories. The territories have increasingly taken a shape similar to the states, yet have far less Senate representation.

[3] See Wikipedia page "Cube Root Rule" which compares 2019 population to 2019 size of lower house of parliament for 37 OECD countries
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cube_root_rule#Table_comparing_OECD_nations_in_2019

Figure 6: Enrolment at federal elections in Tasmania and the Australian Capital Territory, 1975-2025



The population of the Australian Capital Territory has been growing quite quickly, to the point that it is roughly 81.5% of the population of Tasmania (as of the 2021 census). Tasmania elects six times as many senators as the ACT with a slightly larger population.

Examining enrolment numbers for these two jurisdictions, Tasmania contained 226% of the enrolment of the ACT in 1975, when the ACT first elected senators. This figure has dropped to 128% as of 2025.

This discrepancy – where "equal representation" applies as far as Tasmania, but no further – cannot be morally or politically justified. We know that Tasmania's position is guaranteed under the Constitution, and the territories have no such guarantee, but that does not prevent the Parliament from bringing the territories closer to the states in terms of representation.

If the ACT's population continues to grow closer to that of Tasmania, it will become increasingly untenable to leave the ACT with such a small proportion of Tasmania's Senate representation.

I am not arguing for entirely equal representation, but the two populated Territories should have at least four senators each. Arguably you could justify giving those two territories enough senators to give them a similar ratio of representation as Tasmania.

Table 3: Territory population as a proportion of Tasmania's population
How does the population of the ACT and the Northern compare to Tasmania, as of the 2023 apportionment of seats?

State/territory	Population (2023)	Share of Tas. population	Proportionate senators
Tasmania	571,596		12.00
Australian Capital Territory	463,375	81.07%	9.73
Northern Territory	252,576	44.19%	5.30

If the territories were to be given Senate representation in proportion to Tasmania, the ACT would have ten senators and the Northern Territory would have five.

An increase in territorial Senate representation would also help resolve the problem caused by electing two senators at a time – the lack of competitive elections.

In order to be effectively represented in Parliament, it is not sufficient to have representatives who are elected to represent a territory, but that elections there have importance and relevance.

Up until 2022, neither territory had ever elected a Senate delegation that didn't consist of one Labor senator and one Coalition senator. While independent senator David Pocock did win a seat in 2022 at a time of low support for the Coalition, it is likely many future elections will produce a similar result, and often the result is not particularly close.

Where election results are completely predictable and not in play, those electorates can be safely ignored by political parties. Electing four senators would mean one seat is usually in play, and thus the territories would have increased importance in deciding who controls the Senate. I strongly recommend that any new territory senators continue to be elected every three years.

Recommendation 3: The number of Senators elected to represent the Australian Capital Territory and the Northern Territory be increased to at least four, with those Senators continuing to all be up for election at every House election.

Recommendation 4: The committee consider a rule that would set territory Senate representation (and representation of any new states) in proportion to the population of the least populous state.

Caution and delay in redistributions

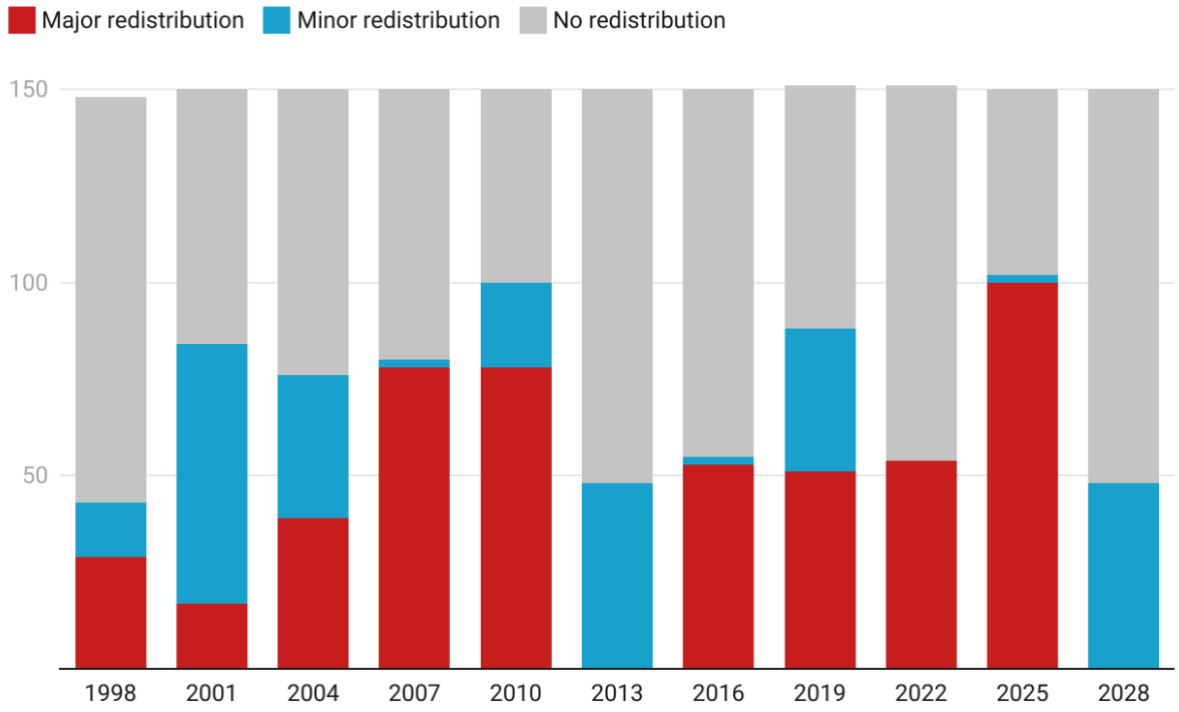
The redistribution procedure is a crucial part of Australia's democratic structures. Ensuring political equality is crucial, but the shape of electoral divisions can also matter for how election campaigns work and how those divisions are represented.

The 2022-2025 redistribution cycle was the most significant redistribution cycle since the expansion of the parliament in 1984. That 1984 cycle involved new maps for all six states and the Australian Capital Territory. The number of seats increased in the five mainland states, and all across Australia a new independent redistribution process was pioneered.

In 2022-25, three states covering two thirds of the House of Representatives conducted what I call a "major redistribution", where that state's seat entitlement changes. A "minor redistribution" was conducted in the Northern Territory.

Figure 7: Scale of federal redistributions, 1998-2028

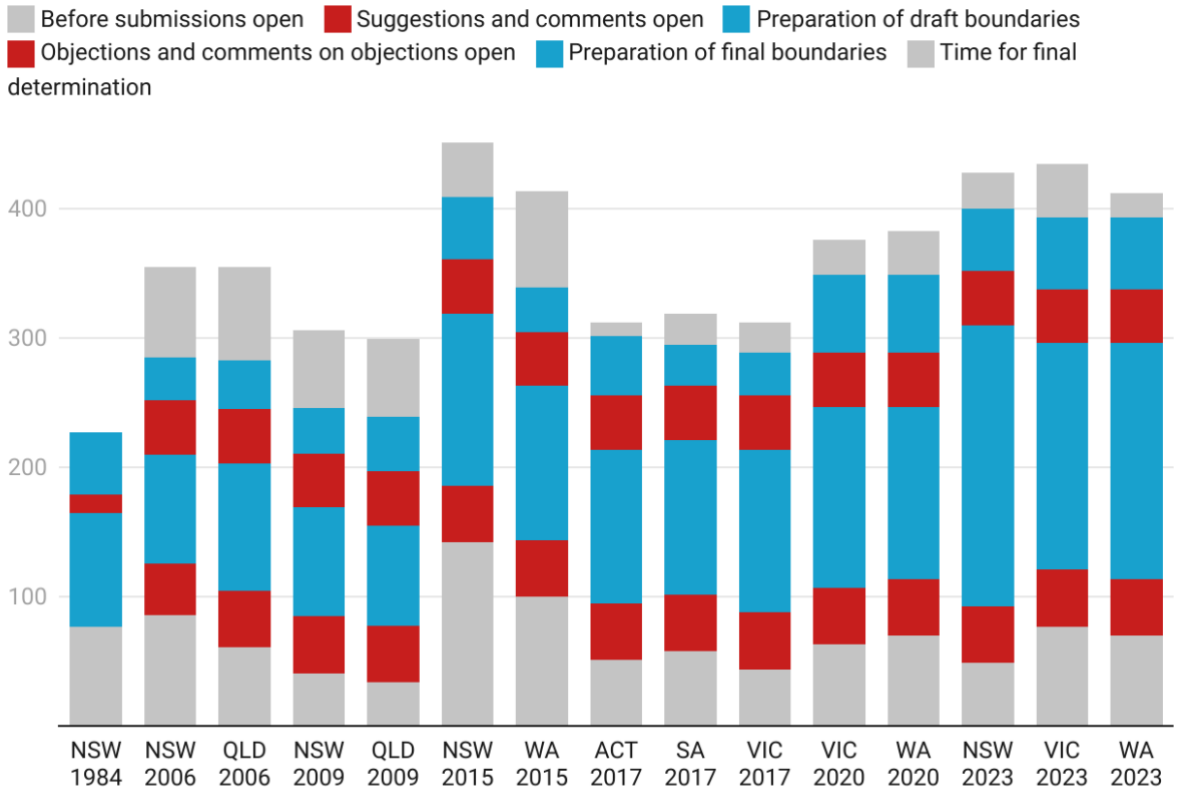
How many seats were effected by redistributions in the lead up to each federal election? "Major" redistributions are those triggered by a change in seat entitlement, "minor" refers to others.



The 2022-25 redistribution cycle also took rather a long time, longer than most major redistributions.

Figure 8: How long does each part of a redistribution take?

How much time, in days, passes in each stage of a federal redistribution process? Public submission periods marked in red, time for the committee to deliberate and prepare boundaries in blue, other administrative periods in grey.



The 1984 redistribution had fewer steps than modern redistributions.

The timeframe for the redistribution was undoubtedly impacted by the unfortunate error in the original population projections for Victoria and Western Australia.

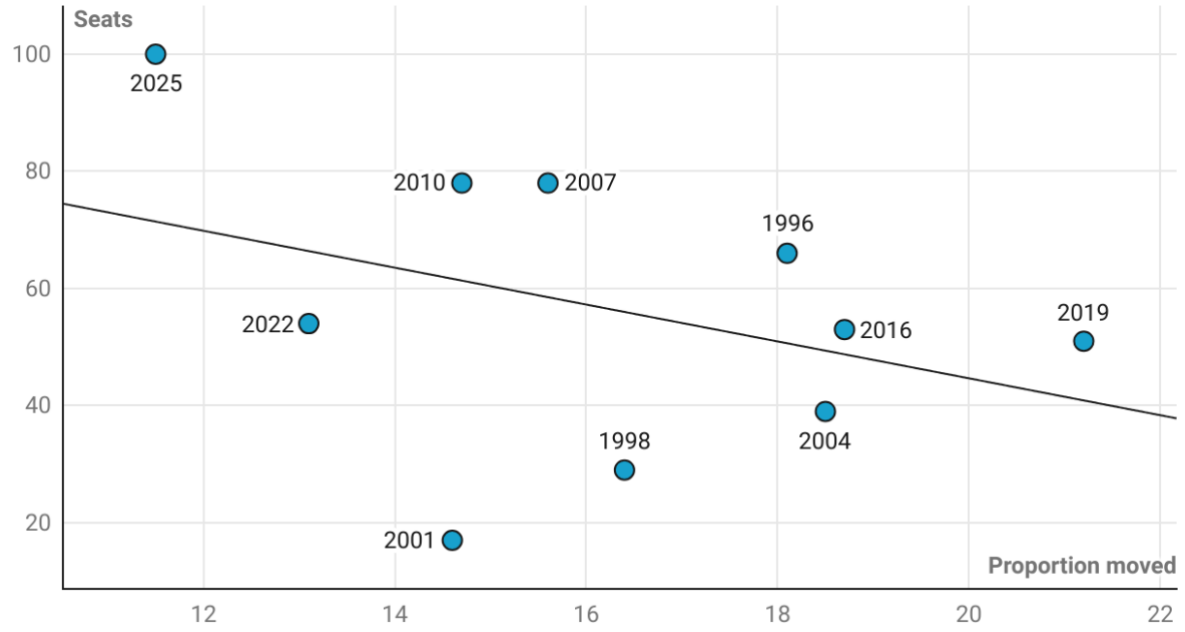
The first rounds of suggestions and comments on suggestions were conducted based on incorrect population data. The draft proposal was published on the correct projection figures, but that seems to have likely added delays to the process.

When examining the number of voters moved to a new electorate at major redistributions since 1994, the 2022-25 cycle produced the smallest changes, and by quite some margin. The second most modest set of changes was in the 2019-22 cycle.

It seems like there may be some relationship between the scale of the job facing the independent mapmakers (in terms of number of seats being redrawn) and the number of voters moved into a new seat.

Figure 9: Playing it safe when the job is bigger?

Where a state's entitlement to seats in the House of Representatives changed, how does the total number of seats redrawn compare to the proportion of voters moved to a new seat?



There are a number of examples of electorates drawn in strange ways during the last redistribution cycle which seems to be explained by avoiding the need to move a larger number of voters in neighbouring seats. These include Kingsford Smith expanding south of Sydney Airport, Melbourne taking in South Yarra rather than Southbank, Kooyong expanding into Toorak and Malvern, and McMahon pushing deeper into Blacktown.[4]

Questions should be asked of the Electoral Commissioner regarding this matter. Does the AEC have sufficient resources to conduct redistributions, in an era with greater numbers of public submissions? Is the criteria to preserve existing boundaries being prioritised even when divisions are drawn with quite bizarre boundaries?

This is particularly of concern if there is to be an expansion of parliament. Such an expansion would trigger a very significant round of redistributions, with a large number of new divisions being drawn. Such a process would necessitate a complete redesign of the electoral map, and that would be an opportunity to improve community of interest connections.

[4] "Are the mapmakers playing it safe?", Ben Raue, *The Tally Room*, 17 September 2025 https://www.tallyroom.com.au/61965